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Quality in Early Childhood Education through the Lenses of Social Justice and Cultural Diversity

Introduction

The term quality in early childhood education (ECE) is not easily defined and has been used in a variety of ways. There is a growing recognition of quality in Aotearoa New Zealand that goes beyond structural measures to encompass social justice and cultural responsiveness. This essay explores the question of quality in ECE from these two perspectives. It first provides a definition of quality and a critique of the traditional measure of staff to child ratios. It then explores equitable access as explored through the 20 Hours ECE policy. Finally, it examines the concept of cultural responsiveness, its links to equity and wider view of quality in early childhood settings, and how the competency of whanaungatanga (from Tātaiako, Ministry of Education, 2011) contributes to this.

Defining Quality and the Limitations of Staff-to-Child Ratios

The concept of quality in ECE is generally recognised as a relational and multidimensional concept. This covers structural characteristics like ratios, group size, qualifications, and process characteristics like the warmth of interactions, the responsiveness of pedagogy and the inclusion of children's cultural identities (Mitchell, 2019; OECD, 2018). Te Whāriki (Ministry of Education, 2017) in Aotearoa establishes quality in terms of reciprocal and respectful relationships between tamariki, kaiako and whānau, with a focus on the principles of empowerment, holistic development, family and community, and relationships.

One of the traditional measures of quality is the ratio of staff to children. For centre based services (Education (Early Childhood Services) Regulations 2008), ratios are regulated at one adult to five children for under-twos and one adult to ten children for over-twos in Aotearoa. A lower ratio is associated with an increased frequency of adult–child interaction, with adults paying closer attention to safety, and with the ability to be more attentive to the individual child (OECD, 2018). For these reasons, ratios continue to be a key tool in policy discussions regarding quality.

Rather, Ratios only reflect the structural conditions of quality, not its content. However, a positive ratio does not necessarily ensure responsive, culturally affirming or pedagogically enhanced interactions (Dalli et al., 2011). The ratios for two centres may be the same but the

experience offered may be very different depending on the knowledge, dispositions and cultural competence of the kaiako. Critically, ratios do not speak to the knowledge that is privileged in the curriculum or whether tamariki Māori and Pasifika see themselves reflected in the everyday practice (Ritchie, 2003). This silence matters in a bicultural context where underpinned by Te Tiriti o Waitangi there can be no neutrality in terms of quality in relation to culture and language. The use of ratios does not provide any indication of the depth of relationality of interactions, of the use of te reo Māori in everyday interactions, or of Pacific languages and worldviews being visible in the learning environment. Overuse of ratios can also further obscure inequities, in communities with more resources, services may be above the minimum number of needed staff and services may be at the minimum number of staff in communities with fewer resources and high staff turnover (Mitchell, 2019). Ratios are thus an important, but limited, indicator of quality and are best interpreted with measures of process quality, equity and cultural responsiveness to better represent the full picture of the complexity of quality in early childhood education.

Social Justice and the 20 Hours ECE Policy

Social justice in ECE relates to fairness in access, participation and outcomes for all tamariki and specifically those who have been historically marginalised. This would be a commitment to the rights of tamariki to access to equitable, accessible, and culturally affirming education under Te Tiriti o Waitangi, the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child and the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples. One of the key social justice issues is quality ECE for children from low-income whānau, with a long history of inequalities across ethnic and socioeconomic groups (Mitchell, 2019).

The government's main way of tackling the issue is the 20 Hours ECE policy, introduced in 2007. The policy is designed to make financial barriers to participation lower and to increase participation, especially for Māori, Pasifika, and lower-income families by providing funding for up to 30 hours of ECE per week at participating services for 3-5 year olds (Ministry of Education, 2020). There is evidence that the policy has had a positive impact on participation and attendance for longer periods, particularly in areas with a greater need (Mitchell, 2019).

But the policy's effects on equity are more mixed. Voluntary for services, and many have optional fees or what's called a 'donation', which means that it is actually a cost barrier (Mitchell, 2019). Access to quality is not always equal to quality, and quality of services

participating is not consistent. Pasifika scholarship has also raised concerns about how mainstream services allocate hours of provision without taking into account Pasifika tamariki's culture and language, and hence the substantive equity that the policy is intended to achieve (Ministry of Education, 2018). The 20 Hours ECE policy therefore goes forward structurally in a way that is fair, but other questions of inclusion and cultural relevance remain. A social-justice approach to quality takes more than hours of access, it involves the context in which tamariki learn, the languages and worldviews that are supported and fostered in that learning, and the resourcing of services that are used by communities most impacted by inequity (Bishop & Glynn, 1999).

Whanaungatanga and Culturally Responsive Practice

Culturally responsive practice embeds cultural identity and relationships in the learning process and makes it more than just a part of the learning experience. In the Ministry of Education document, Aotearoa: Cultural Competencies for Teachers of Māori Learners (2011), there are five competencies that provide guidance for kaiako to honour Te Tiriti iwi o Ngāti Māori, these competencies include whanaungatanga, manaakitanga, tangata whenuatanga, ako and wānanga. Of these, whanaungatanga – active building and sustaining relationships with ākonga, whānau, hapū and iwi – is a key element of quality in ECE.

Whanaungatanga is a concept of quality that is redefined as a relationship. It needs kaiako to have knowledge of each child in their whakapapa, to engage whānau as knowing partners in learning and to establish trust over time (Ministry of Education, 2011). This aligns with the principle of family and community in Te Whāriki (Ministry of Education, 2017) and research which shows that one of the most consistent factors that impacts on children's wellbeing and engagement in services is the quality of the relationship between the home and the service (Bishop & Glynn, 1999; Ritchie, 2003).

Equity is a critical issue in whanaungatanga as it involves a move of power. Whanaungatanga empowers whānau to be co-educators and provides opportunities for whānau to share their expertise and the aspirations for their tamariki that are central to the whakapapa, tikanga and curriculum. This questions the monoculturalism of the mainstream service and helps to ensure that tamariki Māori learn as Māori which is an important component of the quality from a Te Tiriti perspective. The competency is not without its problems when it is actually implemented. For some kaiako who don't feel confident in the reo Māori and tikanga, whanaungatanga might

not exist, or may appear only in the form of greetings and 'cultural' references (Ritchie, 2003). Those who are more likely to embed Whanaungatanga will have continuous professional learning, leadership commitment and time, structural supports from services and wider sector. When embedded, it expands the definition of quality itself, however. Alongside ratios and curriculum coverage, quality is now also assessed by the depth of relationships with whānau, how much the curriculum is tangatahua Māori-visible and how equitable are the outcomes for tamariki Māori (Ministry of Education, 2011).

Conclusion

Structural measures are not sufficient for assessing the quality of early childhood education. In this essay, staff-child ratios have been suggested as a partial measure; the 20 Hours ECE policy is a step towards increasing access but fails to address equity; and whanaungatanga is a new concept that redefines quality as a relational, culturally-based form of care. Together, read through the lenses of social justice and cultural diversity, quality is about fairness, voice and responsiveness as well as structure. For kaiako in Aotearoa it means an ongoing commitment to Te Tiriti o Waitangi, continual professional learning and working in partnership, not alongside, whānau in the centre of quality in early childhood education and care, not on the periphery.

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